

## 2.3 Motherboards

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The motherboard is the base for all other components in the computer. Without the motherboard, the computer will be what it looks like from the outside: a tin box. It's the motherboard that accommodates all other devices like the sound card and LAN card, and it provides connectivity for external devices that are not accommodated on the motherboard physically, such as the hard drive or external USB drives, so that they can communicate with the processor. The motherboard is also a determinant in the performance factor of the computer.

There is a difference in the quality of the motherboards available in the market. For instance, you can opt for a cheap, on-board audio, video solution—or you can go for a high-priced, overclocker-friendly motherboard priced on the higher side. 'Good-quality' motherboards with an efficient architecture are more often higher in the performance ratings than regular motherboards. In fact, some motherboards are pushed in the market as high-performance. These motherboards are also priced higher than their 'regular' counterparts. Do a lot of research before making a decision.

When it comes to upgrading motherboards, look for a long-term investment. Processors, add-on cards and optical drives will come and go, but motherboards stay for years. So when you're upgrading your old motherboard, you may want to look at something that lasts you for at least four to five years.

When we are talking about motherboards, we can again refer to the same three categories that were discussed during the processor upgrade section. We will not be talking about the older motherboards that housed the Pentium I and equivalent AMD processors. Another point here is that currently, there are no motherboards available in the market that support Pentium II or III processors. Any upgrade would mean that you will have to move to a new motherboard supporting newer processors. Then again,